

For about six months now, the village has not imported any power from the grid and has instead been supplying green power. It has become the first village in India to become a net renewable energy generator. According to an official from the Gujarat Power Corporation Ltd, the government agency anchoring the project, about 6,332 kWh of power is generated daily. Modhera consumes about 6,000 kWh per day, and the rest is given to the grid. Solar panels are also installed over government buildings, and the popular Sun Temple is now literally powered by solar energy. It also hosts an electric charging facility for motor vehicles, a free service often utilised by tourists. Daytime power is supplied through solar panels, and after sunset, electricity is supplied via the Battery Energy Storage System, the plant for which is situated in Sujjanpura village, about 6 km from Modhera.

Many in Modhera can now dream of a slightly better quality of life. Most people in the village are small farmers, agricultural labourers or livestock herders. "The average income of each household ranges from Rs 8,000 to Rs 10,000. About 500 households are educated, and many youth are employed in automobile factories nearby. Their incomes are around Rs 15,000-Rs 25,000," says Jatanben Thakor, the village sarpanch. Even a few hundred extra rupees saved at the end of each month is a substantial amount for the families. Amratlal Prajapati, for example, a retired clerk from the tourism department, is planning to give a complete makeover to his house, while his wife Savita is hoping to include more vegetables and fruits in the family's diet. Prajapati hasn't received an electricity bill in four months now because of the solar panel on his rickety rooftop.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Whenever there is a mention of solar power in the world, Modhera will stand out"

— PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI

(at Modhera in October 2022)

These achievements haven't gone unnoticed. In October 2022, Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited Modhera and declared it India's first village that meets its complete energy needs with solar power. Soon after, United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres visited the place and lauded the efforts: "What is amazing, and we must thank in a very emotional way the people of this village, and also the government of Gujarat and the government of India, is that here there is a reconciliation between humankind and the planet."

The transformation of Modhera has made the village shine on the global map as a symbol of possibilities, showing the way for not just India's but the world's efforts towards sustainable living. ■

Well Worth It

Happiness delivery: The Million Wells campaign is striving to rejuvenate Bengaluru's groundwater table while providing a livelihood to the Mannu Vaddar well-digging community

By **AJAY SUKUMARAN**

MILLION WELLS FOR BENGALURU
FOUNDED: 2015
Bengaluru, Karnataka

Fourteen years ago, S. Vishwanath was getting on his motorcycle somewhere in south Bengaluru when a man tapped him on the shoulder, asking if he wanted a well. That's right, a water well. A rainwater harvesting enthusiast, Vishwanath was nonetheless flabbergasted by the random question. In the conversation that ensued, he started to learn of the numerous open wells in Bengaluru up until the mid-1980s when borewells began to take over. And how the Mannu Vaddar community that made a living from digging these open wells was gradually finding itself out of work. The idea of a campaign to dig a million wells for Bengaluru was thus born.

"If we have a million wells, Bengaluru will never run short of water," says Vishwanath, an urban planner who was on a committee to frame bylaws for rainwater harvesting in the burgeoning city. It's a straightforward argument. If the city's annual rainfall is averaged out over 365 days, Bengaluru